three duties (payment of a small land tax, military service within Poland only, and the upkeep of castles and fortifications). He also redistributed hundreds of acres of royal land among them. He then rarely came into Poland, and for twelve years, the united kingdoms of Hungary and Poland were a single realm only on paper.[5]

Unfortunately, Louis shared his uncle's inability to father a son. Before he died, in 1382, he had arranged for his oldest surviving daughter, ten-year-old Mary, to succeed him as queen of Hungary and Poland; he had also arranged her marriage to the Roman Emperor Charles IV's teenaged second son, Sigismund.

But after his funeral, the aristocrats of both countries objected to Mary's rule. In Poland, a strong party of dukes argued for election of Mary's younger sister Hedwig instead; this would break the union of the two crowns and preserve Poland's separate existence. In Hungary, a dissenting party of Hungarian nobles who disliked the idea of female rule invited the king of Naples (the southern part of Italy, separate from Sicily for the last century) to come in and take the crown.[6]

The Hungarian disagreement turned out much bloodier than the Polish. The king of Naples, Charles II, arrived in Hungary in 1386. He was assassinated a month later, by agents of Mary's mother Elizabeth, who had hoped to rule as regent for her young daughter. In retaliation, the supporters of the dead king kidnapped Mary and her mother and dragged them off to Croatia, where, in a mountain fortress, Elizabeth was strangled in front of her daughter's eyes.[7]

Sigismund (with his father's assistance) put together a force of German soldiers and Venetian sailors and arrived in Hungary a few months later. By a combination of force and concessions, he managed to negotiate Mary's release and also claim the throne of Hungary for himself. The antiqueen contigent, pacified by his promise that Mary would have no more power than a queen consort, finally accepted his claim.

Mary, suspecting that her new husband had been complicit in her mother's death, refused to live with him. He was no more enthusiastic than she was; the two occupied separate households until her accidental death in a riding accident in 1395. She was twenty-four, pregnant with their first child; her death prevented the crown from passing out of Sigismund's hands, and after that he reigned alone as king of Hungary.

Meanwhile, little Hedwig, not yet eleven, had been crowned king on October 16, 1384. The Polans had no other way to designate a ruling queen, a *queen regnant*, since Polish queens had always simply been wives of the king. But the name *king* did not solve the primary problem: their country, newly